

WOW!

The biggest crustacean on Earth is the Japanese giant spider crab, which can have legs spanning almost 13 ft (4 m) from tip to tip.

NEW SKIN

One problem with having a strong external skeleton is that it will not stretch as the animal grows. This means that a crustacean such as this crab has to keep shedding its shell and growing a new one.

When the crab slips out of its old, hard shell, it has a soft, stretchy skin that it has to pump up to a larger size before it hardens. During this time, the crab has no defenses and must hide from its enemies.



▲ STAGE 1

The old shell (orange) splits open at the back, revealing a new, soft shell underneath. The crab then climbs out of its old shell.



▲ STAGE 2

The crab expands its soft shell by pumping water into its body; it takes about three days for the shell to harden.

► WHALE BARNACLES

These crustaceans spend their entire life attached to the whale.

Openings in their shells allow them to extend their feathery arms to catch food.



SETTLING DOWN

Barnacles are tiny marine animals that look very different from other crustaceans. They begin life like drifting crab larvae, but when they turn into adults, they cement themselves to hard surfaces. Here, the barnacles grow strong plates, and spend the rest of their lives sieving the water for food. Some even attach themselves to the skin of whales.

